

RE-EVALUATING STRATEGIES FOR MEASURING SEXUAL HARASSMENT IN THE DEBATE AND FORENSIC COMMUNITY

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Many articles published in recent years have attempted to document the incidence of sexual harassment in college debate (e.g., Stepp, Simerly, & Logue, 1994; Szwapa, 1994; Stepp, 2001; Stepp & Gardner, 2001). These articles have generally relied on some version of Fitzgerald and Shullman's Sexual Experiences Questionnaire (SEQ). The SEQ is a series of dichotomous items where respondents are asked to indicate whether or not they have experienced a certain type of behavior (e.g., an unwanted attempt to engage in a discussion of the respondent's personal or sex life). The questions are designed to measure various aspects of sexual harassment, such as gender harassment and sexual coercion. Responses to each question are tallied and used as indicators of the level and type of sexual harassment that exist in the debate community.

Those who have conducted this research should be commended for addressing a difficult and controversial subject. Further, the earliest of these works were especially helpful, in that they gave members of the debate community an opportunity to glimpse the extent of sexual harassment in intercollegiate debate. What is disappointing is that more recent research offers relatively few new insights about sexual harassment and that it merely repeats the strategies of previous research, with no attempts to correct the flaws or offer additional content. Thus, it seems that a re-evaluation of attempts to document sexual harassment is in order.

This essay begins by discussing research design and measurement issues where research on sexual harassment in intercollegiate debate is concerned. After turning to questions of statistical analysis and interpretation in this research, the essay concludes with a discussion of the effectiveness of the policies designed to date to deal with sexual harassment in intercollegiate debate.

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Research Design and Measurement Issues

This section addresses a variety of issues regarding design and measurement in recent research, including representativeness, differences in validity and reliability, measurement and classification concerns, and gender differences. Also, this section considers predictive modeling and latent variables as they are treated in these studies.

Representativeness of Recent Research. There is little evidence to justify most claims of representativeness in studies that attempt to measure the incidence of sexual harassment in speech and debate activities. Most studies (Stepp & Gardner, 2001; Stepp, 2001; Szwapa, 1994; Stepp, Simerly, & Logue, 1994) rely on convenience studies administered at the national tournament. Researchers need to be able to demonstrate that competitors at such tournaments are similar to the type of competitors, on average, that can be found at most tournaments during the regular season (in terms of gender, size of program, amount of yearly travel, etc.). Absent supporting documentation on such characteristics, we cannot make any assumptions about whether survey respondents at these tournaments can reveal anything about the experiences of the speech or debate community at large. Thus, it would be invalid to draw conclusions, for example, about whether sexual harassment in CEDA is on the rise on the basis of such studies. (In fairness, much social-scientific research in intercollegiate debate suffers from these same problems.)

Indeed, it is more likely that participants at such tournaments are not representative of the general communities for which the inferences are being drawn. The AFA and NFA speech tournaments, as well as the NDT, require participants to qualify in order to attend. Thus participants in surveys administered at such tournaments are more likely to attend schools with well-funded programs, and, as a result, are more likely to be among the more highly traveled element of their respective communities. Such individuals, all other things being equal, may experience more harassment simply as a result of the fact that they attend more tournaments and should encounter a more diverse group of participants, coaches, and judges. Even at the CEDA national tournament, which does not use a qualifying system, highly traveled “national circuit” teams may be overrepresented, as poorly funded regional programs may have to skip the national tournament if that tournament is far removed from a program’s home campus.

Moreover, a potential problem exists with respondent selection bias that is not adequately addressed in any of the studies. Because surveys must be filled out while at the tournament, where participants have little free time and limited privacy, there will most

likely be a non-random set of survey participants. Individuals who have experienced harassment may feel more motivated to fill out the survey than those who have no harassment complaints. In other cases, a lack of privacy may compromise responses, which will make findings less useful in making inferences about the general population of participants in the activity.

Ultimately, then, convenience surveys administered at national tournaments are not likely to reveal the actual amount of sexual harassment in the debate and forensic community, as we should not make generalizations on the basis of non-representative samples. To find out how much sexual harassment is occurring, we need to reach a larger and more representative amount of the population, or develop a set of weights or corrections to properly estimate the extent of harassment in the community at large. While the extant studies provide a step in the right direction, this should not be the final step. Rather than adhere to the same basic research design year in and year out, future studies should attempt to improve representativeness. While we now know that sexual harassment is a problem for participants in speech and debate activities, we don't know how common it is, or how many individuals are affected.

The Difference between Validity and Reliability. There are also problems of validity that need to be addressed by those researching the problem of sexual harassment in forensics and debate. In using the SEQ, it appears that many researchers neglect validity, focusing instead on the issue of reliability. Validity is the notion that the SEQ actually measures the phenomenon of sexual harassment, rather than some other phenomenon. As Carmines and Zeller (1979) note, one cannot validate a test instrument, but, rather, "an interpretation of the data arising from a specified procedure" (p. 17). There is no single number a researcher can provide that would demonstrate validity. Nor would demonstrating the validity of the SEQ in a workplace setting a priori constitute validation of the study in some other setting with other subjects. Reliability, on the other hand, is the notion that a measure is a consistent, stable indicator of the concept being studied, and in assessing reliability in scales, measures like Cronbach's alpha (which relies on average correlations across items) are commonly used.

Emphasizing reliability to the exclusion of validity is evident in the recent Stepp and Gardner (2001) article, in which the authors acknowledge the use of a modified version of SEQ designed to more accurately represent behavior in the debate community, but report only a Cronbach's alpha of .74 to claim that this SEQ is indeed measuring what they intend

it to measure.¹ However, alpha proves nothing of the sort. Rather, alpha measures average correlations between scale items. An alpha of over .7 suggests that a scale is unidimensional, and that the items all tap the same underlying construct. In other words, a high alpha suggests a high amount of multicollinearity, or interchangeability, in scale items. In the case of the SEQ, such a high alpha is, in fact, problematic, because it suggests that each supposedly independent measure of harassment is, in fact, redundant with every other measure. While researchers may impose artificial categories on SEQ measures such as “seductive behavior” and “sexual bribery,” a high alpha indicates that there is no real difference between these items, or that the scale itself poorly discriminates between different elements or dimensions of sexual harassment.² Rather than demonstrating that the SEQ has high internal validity, a high alpha undermines such claims.

Moreover, alpha is an inappropriate tool for demonstrating validity because it can only evaluate relatedness of scale items. A poorly measured construct, if measures are similar, will still produce a high alpha value. For example, if we chose a battery of economic indicators as measures of presidential approval, they would probably achieve a fairly high alpha value, but such a finding in no way proves that they are valid representations of the concept of presidential approval. As the discussion below will show, there are serious questions about whether the SEQ is equipped to measure sexual harassment, particularly outside of its intended context.

Measurement and Classification Issues. There are serious questions about the appropriateness of a survey designed for the workplace (in this case, the SEQ) being used in settings for which it was not intended. As Stepp (2001) points out, forensic and debate settings are not comparable to a work environment or even a college classroom setting.

¹This statistic is virtually identical to the value reported by Fitzgerald and Shullman in their earliest use of this scale. It is not clear from the Stepp and Gardner article whether they calculated alpha themselves from their own data or were merely using the alpha value reported by previous researchers as support for their contention.

²The original author of the SEQ has acknowledged this problem in her later research. Fitzgerald, Gelfand, and Drasgow (1995) have noted that the high inter-item correlations among items in the SEQ are problematic, suggesting that there is very little differentiation among items.

Competitors travel long hours with coaching staffs (including faculty and graduate students), they share meals, and they share hotel rooms. For serious competitors, the activity may take up most weekends during the semester, as well as many weekday evenings. For the average student, the development of a social life occurs during such time periods; for those who compete in debate and forensic activities, the activity itself may constitute a student's social life.

Existing research on sexual harassment is not well equipped to handle settings that comprise an individual's personal and professional life. While relating personal stories may not be appropriate at work, they may not necessarily be inappropriate in the context of a debate tournament—depending on whether the anecdote takes place in a formal setting (i.e., during a round, or in a conversation between a participant and a judge after the round) or a more informal setting (e.g., at dinner, in a hotel room). Given that debaters and forensic competitors generally have more complex relationships with one another than do co-workers—they are more likely to have close personal friendships, share an apartment, and to form romantic relationships—surveys like the SEQ that are designed to measure workplace harassment may not be entirely appropriate in this context.

Clearly, some behaviors, such as sexual coercion, are never appropriate regardless of the setting. Tasteless jokes exchanged among friends may mean something different among strangers or even casual acquaintances, or when the intent is to demean. Deeply personal anecdotes told over a late-night dinner among colleagues who may merely wish to provide amusement for others are not appropriate when told by a judge to a debater at the tournament, particularly when the intent is to seduce or embarrass the listener.

The problem with workplace questionnaires is that they are not designed to measure behavior in less professional settings. Given the complexity of extracurricular speech activities, both in terms of their settings (professional and social) and the various types of interactions that can occur (between debaters, coaches, and/or judges), it would be useful to be able to classify various events and interactions by several additional factors: 1) who is the instigator (same school or different, same gender or different, as well as the power relationship to the victim); 2) where the incident takes place (formal or informal setting); and 3) intent. The latter classification is the most difficult. For behaviors like sexual coercion, the intent is clear. For less serious items in surveys like the SEQ (telling jokes, personal stories, treating someone differently due to their gender), intent may not always be to seduce or demean, but, rather, to entertain.

In the extreme case, the SEQ would permit acts intended to be chivalrous to be classified as harassment, such as a man holding open a door for a woman, merely because the woman chose to interpret the act in a negative fashion. Indeed, refraining from continuing to relate a naughty story when a member of the opposite sex enters the room can be construed as harassment (being treated differently based on one's gender), while telling the story in the presence of a member of the opposite sex would also be classified as harassment (an offensive story or joke). Such a question can only produce unstable (that is, unreliable) estimates of the type of behavior the researcher is attempting to measure.

The SEQ as used in existing speech research is also limited in that no attempt is made to classify the subject's response to the behavior that the researcher is classifying as harassment. If harassment and consensual flirtation are different things, then, for a measure to be valid, it would also need to assess whether the behavior in question was wanted or unwanted. While threats are presumably always unwanted, suggestive stories, jokes, propositions, or even touching may not always be viewed as unwanted by the subject. This is evident, for example, in the case of forcible contact and male coaches, as reported in one study. The number of forcible contacts reported by Stepp and Gardner (2001) was higher than the number of unwanted contact incidents—suggesting that the former measure includes both harassing and non-harassing behaviors.

It is also problematic that the SEQ does not identify the gender of both parties involved in the incidents reported. Given the consistently higher rates of exposure to offensive jokes among men (see Stepp and Gardner, 2001, as well as the tabular analysis in this article), it is obvious that such jokes are being told by men to other men. Clearly, this is not sexual harassment, in that it is unlikely, given the high exposure rate, that the general intent is to seduce. What is not clear are the circumstances under which women are exposed to these jokes: Is it primarily through men—which is generally assumed to be the case by researchers, but rarely is data provided to support this assumption—is it through contact with women, or is it some combination of the two?

While offensive jokes being told to males by other males may not usually be indicative of seductive intent, it is likely that some of the reported incidents of harassment among males are initiated by other men, and for sexual purposes. Similarly, we cannot assume that all harassment of women is being done by men. A shortcoming of the SEQ is that it does not include questions designed to measure harassment of gays, lesbians, and bisexuals—a problem if the intent is to measure sexual harassment. Anecdotal evidence provided by

Stepp (2001) suggests that this type of harassment does occur in the debate and forensics world, but as yet, it remains unmeasured, and thus, undocumented.

Gender Differences in the Perception of Sexual Harassment. The use of the SEQ to determine whether an individual has been sexually harassed makes some assumptions about how a respondent may perceive an incident as sexual harassment. For example, respondents are asked about being exposed to personal stories and offensive jokes as part of the researcher's attempt to determine whether they have been victims of "seductive behavior." The salience of such recollections, however, can reasonably be expected to vary as a function of the respondent's gender. According to Stockdale, Vaux, and Cashin (1995), reports of sexual harassment vary by a variety of factors, including whether the perpetrator was in a position of authority, and whether the victim was "sensitive to the issue of sexual harassment," a condition more likely to be perceived by women than men. There are also gender-based differences in the ability to discriminate between friendly and sexually interested behavior, with men more likely to perceive a variety of behaviors as sexually interested than women (Abbey, 1982; Shotland & Craig, 1988). These differences may lead to differences in how men and women respond to the questions in the SEQ.

Specifically, such differences should make women more likely than men to express the belief that they have been harassed, even if true rates of harassment are equal across men and women. Moreover, men may be more likely to engage in behavior perceived by women to be harassing because of a mistaken perception that an individual has demonstrated sexual interest. Does a mistake in communication constitute harassment, or is harassment a deliberate attempt to exert power over another person? Most of the research on sexual harassment in the speech and debate community proceeds on the latter assumption, while the measurement instruments being used make no distinction between intentional and unintentional harassment.

The Appropriateness of Logit and Other Forms of Predictive Modeling. In one recent study (Stepp & Gardner, 2001), an attempt is made to build on the basic frequency distribution versions of the SEQ instrument that appear in previous works on sexual harassment and the debate community. Stepp and Gardner treat each SEQ item as a dependent variable, and, because the items are dichotomized, they opt to use a logit (logistic

regression) model to estimate the effects of various group membership variables (male debater, female debater, male coach, female coach).³

Unfortunately, the logit model does not serve to provide any added understanding to the problem of sexual harassment in CEDA beyond what we could glean from a basic frequency distribution. There are several reasons for this. First, the coefficients themselves are not interpretable. The logit model assumes a limited dependent variable, but not necessarily limited (categorical) independent variables. Interpretability of coefficients in a logit model generally requires that the independent variables be scalar, so that differences in probability estimates can be gauged for changes in values of the independent variables. With nominal independent variables, the utility of the logit model boils down to significance tests and goodness of fit measures, which tell us how much variance in the dependent variable is explained by the model.

Second, the statistical significance tests that accompany this model are not particularly helpful in that they only tell us that the coefficient is different from zero. We cannot compare coefficient sizes in order to determine whether being a male debater has a greater effect on the dependent variable than being a female debater. This being the case, it makes more sense to simply perform a difference in means test on the frequency distributions, as this would provide more meaningful information than the probit model.

As with any model grounded in the assumptions of the basic linear model, the viability of the logit model also assumes that the model is fully specified—that is, that all relevant independent variables are included in the model. This is clearly not the case in Stepp and Gardner (2001). Presumably, the likelihood of encountering any particular form of sexual harassment is dependent on things other than whether the individual is a male or a female, or whether they are a coach or a debater. Factors such as the length of time they've spent in the activity, and the amount of time they devote to travel, probably also contribute. Leaving out relevant explanatory variables violates the basic assumptions of the logit model, and may result in inconsistent coefficient estimates, especially if omitted variables are related to any of the included variables (Green, 1990). According to Green, this problem is more serious in logit and probit models than it is in classical regression models.

³Green (1990) notes that disturbances should be normally distributed if the probit model is to be used, whereas logistically distributed disturbances should employ a logit model. It is unclear from their analysis whether Gardner and Stepp's (2001) data meet this criterion.

Treatment of Latent Variables. Ultimately, the problem for all sexual harassment research is that sexual harassment is a latent variable, and there is no one single direct measure of the construct. Rather, researchers devise surveys composed of many different indicators all designed to tap some element of the latent construct. Given that any single element of the SEQ is an imperfect measure of the latent construct, it is puzzling that some communication researchers have chosen to treat them as separate dependent variables in their statistical analyses. This is an undesirable strategy for several reasons. Initially, there is a fair amount of measurement error associated with any single, imperfect measure of a latent construct. If the items in the SEQ are related (which researchers assume they are, and high Cronbach's alpha values seem to substantiate), then related patterns of measurement error will be associated with each measure. This problem of measurement error could be substantially ameliorated by creating some sort of summary scale from the individual items. (See DeVellis, 1991, for an extended discussion of latent variables and scale development.)

The authors of the SEQ scale express similar concerns in their later research. In addition to problems of subjectivity in gauging the seriousness of various harassment behaviors, they argue that to treat the individual scale items as dichotomous variables is "a serious oversimplification." Rather, they suggest developing some sort of scale that weights the frequency of various types of harassment (Fitzgerald, Gelfand, & Drasgow 1995).

A more useful strategy for dealing with a latent variable involves aggregating the various manifest (observable) indicators into a single measure, or perhaps even several dimensions. The easiest way to do this would be a factor analysis where different dimensions of sexual harassment were derived empirically (rather than theoretically), with each respondent receiving a score on each factor (dimension). The factors, or dimensions, would then constitute the dependent variable or variables, and independent variables would measure the kinds of things that influence different types of sexual harassment.

A more complicated version of this strategy would involve a latent covariance structure model (using LISREL or a related program). In such a model, often referred to as confirmatory factor analysis, the researcher decides which measures correspond to which dimensions of the latent variable. Dimensions of the latent variable can be related, and disturbances of the latent variable can be analyzed as well. This model is more flexible for the researcher because interrelationships among latent and measured variables are permitted, as long as the model is identified. It is, however, more complicated to construct.

Other alternatives include IRT-type models (item response theory), such as Mokken scaling (Mokken, 1971). These models work well when measures are dichotomous (although polychotomous scaling strategies are also available). A Mokken scale, for example, is a probabilistic version of a difficulty scale where, for each dichotomous item, responses are arrayed along the scale according to difficulty. “Easy” items would be, in this case, harassment behaviors most frequently reported. “Difficult” items are behaviors that are more rare. The assumption of the Mokken scale is that those responding positively to difficult items will also respond positively to easier items. Non-scalable items are dropped from the analysis, but can be used to create another “dimension” if they scale with other excluded items.⁴

In the context of sexual harassment research, a Mokken scale would be an intriguing direction of study because we could empirically determine if individuals experiencing more serious harassment were also subjected to more mild forms of harassment, and the data would determine the underlying common-uncommon, or easy-difficult dimension. Respondents’ placement on the Mokken scale (or scales) could then be used as a dependent variable in subsequent analyses to determine the underlying causes of the amount and kind of sexual harassment experienced by individuals. Current research strategies do not provide answers to these kinds of questions.

To this point, research design and measurement issues have been considered. The next section concentrates on matters of statistical analysis and interpretation.

Statistical Analysis and Interpretation Issues

In this section, disclosure and data availability, as well as statistical significant testing and aggregation fallacies, will be discussed. Where interpretation of research findings are concerned, this section will address claims that sexual harassment in CEDA is increasing,

⁴For a discussion of Mokken scaling, see Mokken (1971). Mokken scales can be constructed by hand using correlations and crosstabulation tables, or can be done using the MSP software package available from iec ProGAMMA. Mokken and Gutmann scaling techniques are a regular topic in the Scaling and Dimensional Analysis course offered by Bill Jacoby in the ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods at the University of Michigan. The ICPSR program is geared toward teaching quantitative applications to graduate students and mid-career academics.

that women are more likely than men to be harassed, and that harassment is an expression of dominance.

Disclosure and Data Availability Issues. The dialogue surrounding sexual harassment, and, indeed, all other quantitative and pseudo-quantitative research strategies in debate and forensic research could be improved by more stringent standards of disclosure and data availability. Convention in the social sciences requires that when any statistical procedure is used, the full results be disclosed in the article where the findings are reported. All relevant sample sizes should be reported, as should some indication of statistical significance (by reporting standard errors, t values, or the like), and all appropriate measures of goodness of fit. A lack of such information is a problem for any researcher trying to evaluate the Stepp and Gardner (2001) study, for example. While they spend a fair amount of time discussing how their logit model will be set up, the results are reported in a few sentences, no statistical output is shown, no measures of fit are provided, and it is very difficult for another researcher to evaluate their findings. More confusing is the fact that they go on to perform a variety of tests on their frequency distribution (completely unrelated to their logit model) in the same paragraph that they casually discard their logit model, leaving the statistically inexperienced reader to assume that the findings being discussed are products of the logit model when, in fact, they are not.

In this case, incomplete reporting serves to obscure the fact that *no meaningful interactions* were found using the more powerful logit technique. An absence of interactions among gender, role and year indicates an absence of support for the claim that harassment of women, for example, has increased. Stepp and Gardner instead use an aggregated comparison, in essence, to attempt to disprove their own logit findings. The exact formula being used for their alternative strategy is not discussed, nor are the details of their statistical strategy. It is not clear which groups are being aggregated, or what the justification for such aggregation might be. Further, no output is provided, and no standards for evaluating whatever output the researchers had access to are provided.

Requiring researchers to submit original data to either journals or an external data repository for replication studies by other researchers would also serve to enhance the study of sexual harassment and other issues in the debate and forensic community. Some journals in the social sciences make this a pre-condition of publication, as does the National Science Foundation (for those using NSF-funded data for publication purposes).

Statistical Significance Testing and Aggregation Fallacies. The problem of aggregating data, as noted above, is that aggregation may produce findings that are not supported by an analysis of individual level data. For example, minor, non-significant differences in logit results for the different dependent variables examined by Stepp and Gardner may appear significant when the dependent variables are combined simply as a function of the aggregation process. However, such a phenomenon does not permit us to simply discard the findings of the logit analysis and rely on the aggregated findings instead. If tests for individual level differences fail, then we simply cannot conclude that there are individual differences on the basis of an aggregated test. A strong relationship between gender and harassment for a single dependent variable, for one particular role group (i.e., coaches), combined with non-significant differences for other measures of the dependent variables and other role groups, could produce a significant difference in aggregate, but such an approach would seriously misrepresent the level of harassment going on at the individual level (i.e., for each different item on the SEQ, and for each role group).

A more straightforward approach involves conducting a simple t-test on the difference in means between groups (male debaters versus female debaters, male coaches versus female coaches, female debaters in 1994 compared to female debaters in 1999, etc.). The table below shows the Stepp and Gardner (2001) percentages for reported instances of harassment. For each percentage, the number of individuals in each group was calculated using the total N for each group provided by the original authors. The formula for calculating a test statistic for the difference between two percentages is shown below in equation 1:

$$t = \frac{P_{Group1} - P_{Group2}}{\sqrt{\frac{P_{Group1}(1 - P_{Group1})}{N_{Group1}} + \frac{P_{Group2}(1 - P_{Group2})}{N_{Group2}}}} \quad (Eq.1)$$

Where t = the test statistic

P = the proportion for each group (thus, 48%, expressed as a proportion, would be .48)

(P(1-P))/N calculation = the standard error for each group percentage, or proportion

To determine whether the differences in proportion between two groups are statistically meaningful, the test statistic should be compared to a critical value from the Student's t distribution. The null hypothesis is always that the differences are not meaningfully

different from zero. To reject this hypothesis with a 95 percent level of confidence, the test statistic should exceed the critical value obtained from the t-distribution, which will vary according to the sample size the researcher is examining; the smaller the sample size, the higher the critical value, and the lower the probability that the null hypothesis can be rejected. Alternatively, most statistical packages will calculate a probability value for this test. Probability values (p-values) equal to or less than .05 indicate that observed differences between groups are statistically meaningful.

For researchers lacking access to common statistical packages such as SPSS and SAS, this simple test in Equation 1 can easily be calculated by hand. For those without access to statistical software and who do not wish to do hand calculations, other options are available. The Department of Statistics at the University of South Carolina has developed a web-based statistical package called WebStat that is free and designed for less experienced users.

Is Sexual Harassment in CEDA on the Rise? To evaluate Stepp and Gardner's (2001) claim that instances of sexual harassment in CEDA have increased since the adoption of a sexual harassment policy, reported harassment for each group in 1994 is compared to that group's reported harassment in 1999 using the formula in Equation 1. Figures that demonstrate a statistically significant increase (based on a two-tailed t-test with an alpha of .05, or a confidence level of 95 percent) in harassment between 1994 and 1999 are indicated by an asterisk. The results of this analysis are reported in Table 1.

Table 1a. Group Comparisons, 1994 Versus 1999, Part I

	Male Debaters	Female Debaters
1. Suggestive stories, offensive jokes	Male debater 1994 75% (120/160). Male debater 1999 83.3% (90/108) t = 1.624 (p = .104)	Female debater 1994 63.5% (54/85) Female debater 1999 76.7% (57/74) t = 1.849 (p = .064)
2. Treated differently due to gender	Male debater 1994 25% (40/160) Male debater 1999 32.7% (35/108) t = 1.325 (p = .185)	Female debater 1994 64.7% (55/85) Female debater 1999 78.1% (58/74) t = 1.896 (p = .058)
3. Sexist remarks	Male debater 1994 21.9% (35/160) Male debater 1999 27.8% (30/108) t = 1.106 (p = .269)	Female debater 1994 52.9% (45/85) Female debater 1999 60.3% (45/74) t = 0.999 (p = .318)
4. Discussion of personal or sexual matters	Male debater 1994 30% (48/160) Male debater 1999 36.7% (40/108) t = 1.203 (p = .229)	Female debater 1994 40% (34/85) Female debater 1999 50% (37/74) t = 1.265 (p = .206)

Table 1a. Group Comparisons, 1994 Versus 1999, Part I (Cont.)

5. Unwanted seductive behavior	Male debater 1994	18.8% (30/160)	Female debater 1994	34.1% (29/85)
	Male debater 1999	36.7% (40/108)	Female debater 1999	44.6% (33/74)
	t = 3.343* (p = .001)		t = 1.351 (p = .177)	
6. Bribe with some reward	Male debater 1994	1.9% (3/160)	Female debater 1994	11.8% (10/85)
	Male debater 1999	1.9% (2/108)	Female debater 1999	13.5% (10/74)
	t = 0.017 (p = .989)		t = 0.332 (p = .740)	
7. Unwanted sexual behavior due to rewards	Male debater 1994	0.0% (0/160)	Female debater 1994	0.0% (0/85)
	Male debater 1999	0.9% (1/108)	Female debater 1999	2.7% (2/74)
	t = 1.219 (p = .223)		t = 1.525 (p = .127)	
8. Negative consequence for non-cooperation	Male debater 1994	0.6% (1/160)	Female debater 1994	9.4% (8/85)
	Male debater 1999	0.9% (1/108)	Female debater 1999	5.5% (4/74)
	t = 0.281 (p = .779)		t = -0.954 (p = .340)	
9. Threats for non-cooperation	Male debater 1994	0.6% (1/160)	Female debater 1994	3.5% (3/85)
	Male debater 1999	0.0% (0/108)	Female debater 1999	1.4% (1/74)
	t = -0.823 (p = .410)		t = -0.875 (p = .382)	
10. Forceful attempts to touch, kiss, grab	Male debater 1994	3.8% (6/160)	Female debater 1994	17.7% (15/85)
	Male debater 1999	3.7% (4/108)	Female debater 1999	19.2% (14/74)
	t = -0.017 (p = .984)		t = .061 (p = .836)	
11. Unwanted attempt to touch or fondle	Male debater 1994	5.0% (8/160)	Female debater 1994	16.5% (14/85)
	Male debater 1999	4.7% (5/108)	Female debater 1999	24.7% (18/74)
	t = -0.138 (p = .890)		t = 1.232 (p = .218)	

* $p \leq .05$, two-tailed test

Note: Figures in parentheses are frequencies. For each cell, a t-statistic and a probability value based on the t-statistic and the sample size are provided. Calculations were done on data provided in Stepp and Gardner (2001).

Table 1b. Group Comparisons, 1994 Versus 1999, Part II

	Male Coaches		Female Coaches	
1. Suggestive stories, offensive jokes	Male coach 1994	90.6% (48/53)	Female coach 1994	88.2% (15/17)
	Male coach 1999	92.9% (40/43)	Female coach 1999	100% (24/24)
	t = 0.433 (p = .665)		t = 1.723 (p = .085)	
2. Treated differently due to gender	Male coach 1994	30.2% (16/53)	Female coach 1994	64.7% (11/17)
	Male coach 1999	39.5% (17/43)	Female coach 1999	95.8% (23/24)
	t = 1.896 (p = .058)		t = 2.620* (p = .009)	

Table 1b. Group Comparisons, 1994 Versus 1999, Part II (Cont.)

3. Sexist remarks	Male coach 1994 32.1% (17/53) Male coach 1999 48.8% (21/43) t = 1.670 (p = .095)	Female coach 1994 70.6% (12/17) Female coach 1999 91.3% (22/24) t = 1.767 (p = .077)
4. Discussion of personal or sexual matters	Male coach 1994 47.2% (25/53) Male coach 1999 54.8% (23/43) t = 0.616 (p = .538)	Female coach 1994 70.6% (12/17) Female coach 1999 75.0% (18/24) t = 0.314 (p = .753)
5. Unwanted seductive behavior	Male coach 1994 24.5% (13/53) Male coach 1999 27.9% (12/43) t = 0.375 (p = .708)	Female coach 1994 41.2% (7/17) Female coach 1999 54.2% (13/24) t = 0.820 (p = .412)
6. Bribed with some reward	Male coach 1994 11.3% (6/53) Male coach 1999 7.0% (3/43) t = -0.726 (p = .468)	Female coach 1994 11.8% (2/17) Female coach 1999 12.5% (3/24) t = 0.071 (p = .943)
7. Unwanted sexual behavior due to rewards	Male coach 1994 3.8% (2/53) Male coach 1999 2.3% (1/43) t = -0.405 (p = .685)	Female coach 1994 0.0% (0/17) Female coach 1999 0.0% (0/24) t = 0.000 (p = .999)
8. Negative conseq. for non-cooperation	Male coach 1994 11.3% (6/53) Male coach 1999 4.7% (2/43) t = -1.176 (p = .240)	Female coach 1994 11.8% (2/17) Female coach 1999 0.0% (0/24) t = -1.723 (p = .0849)
9. Threats for non-cooperation	Male coach 1994 5.7% (3/53) Male coach 1999 2.3% (1/43) t = -0.813 (p = .416)	Female coach 1994 11.8% (2/17) Female coach 1999 12.5% (3/24) t = 0.071 (p = .943)
10. Forcible attempts to touch, kiss, grab	Male coach 1994 9.4% (5/53) Male coach 1999 11.6% (5/43) t = 0.350 (p = .726)	Female coach 1994 23.5% (4/17) Female coach 1999 16.7% (4/24) t = 0.546 (p = .585)
11. Unwanted attempt to touch or fondle	Male coach 1994 18.9% (10/53) Male coach 1999 9.3% (4/43) t = -1.320 (p = .187)	Female coach 1994 29.4% (5/17) Female coach 1999 20.8% (5/24) t = -0.630 (p = .529)

* $p \leq .05$, two-tailed test

Note: Figures in parentheses are frequencies. For each cell, a t-statistic and a probability value based on the t-statistic and the sample size are provided. Calculations were done on data provided in Stepp and Gardner (2001).

In many cases, the number of individuals who report being subjected to a threat for non-cooperation or a forcible attempt to touch, kiss, or grab is about the same from one year to

the next across both gender groups and debaters and coaches. The percentages differ slightly only because the sample sizes varied from one year to the next. In most cases there was little meaningful change from one year to the next. Ultimately, for male debaters, there are almost no statistically significant increases (or decreases) in any of the measures of sexual harassment between 1994 and 1999, using a two-tailed t-test and a 95 percent confidence level.⁵ The only instance of an increase in harassment found indicates that male debaters were more likely to experience unwanted seductive behavior in 1999 than they had been in 1994. For female debaters, the pattern is even more clear: There is no statistically significant increase in reported sexual harassment from 1994 to 1999 for any of the behaviors measured.

In the case of coaches, male coaches demonstrated no statistically meaningful changes in reported sexual harassment between 1994 and 1999. For female coaches, only reports of perceived differences in treatment as a result of gender went up from 1994 to 1999; everything else remained unchanged. These results do not make a compelling argument for any discernible change in sexual harassment over time. At best, we can say that male debaters are receiving more unwanted advances and female coaches in the study may be experiencing more perceived gender discrimination now than previously. But, such findings do not demonstrate, on the whole, a more hostile environment for most participants. Rather, they indicate that things are the same. While Stepp and Gardner (2001) may claim otherwise, a closer examination of these data suggests that such claims are unsupported.

Are Women More Likely to be Harassed than Men? Many studies (i.e., Stepp, Simerly, & Logue, 1994; Szwapa, 1994) are unable to answer this question because virtually no statistical significance tests are performed to determine if apparent gender differences are meaningful, or are merely artifacts. The only attempts thus far to examine the data more rigorously can be found in the work of Stepp (2001) and Stepp and Gardner (2001). In both cases, some sort of significance test was conducted specifically to examine gender differences in harassment. However, those tests were aggregate in nature and did not examine gender differences in individuals in the same roles. Combining debaters and coaches together may obscure differences in harassment that arise as a function of the individual's role in the debate (or speech) community.

⁵Although using a one-tailed test and a 95 percent confidence level, male debaters were more likely to report "unwanted seductive behavior" in 1999 than they were in 1994.

Some brief comparisons of gender differences in harassment were calculated, based on the Stepp and Gardner (2001) data. These are shown in Table 2. Unlike the Stepp and Gardner analysis, which involved aggregated comparisons, male and female debaters are specifically compared in Table 2 for every SEQ item, and a separate analysis for male and female coaches has been conducted. Because debaters and coaches presumably are exposed to different dynamics (in terms of settings, types of contacts, relative power position, etc.), gender comparisons are performed separately for debaters and coaches. Because there were almost no meaningful differences in patterns of harassment for any group between 1994 and 1999, the two years were pooled for these comparisons. These findings are reported in Table 2. Statistically significant differences between men and women are illustrated with an asterisk (based on a two-tailed t-test with an alpha of .05, or a confidence level of 95 percent).

The findings support the conclusions of Stepp (2001) and Stepp and Gardner (2001). Specifically, females are more likely to be harassed than males. If comparisons are made among debaters for almost every type of sexual harassment studied, females were significantly more likely to be harassed than males. There were only two exceptions. For suggestive stories or offensive jokes, the pattern is reversed, with male debaters experiencing such harassment significantly more than female debaters. For “unwanted sexual behavior due to rewards” (item number 7), there were no discernible gender differences among debaters. Overall, it seems that female debaters compete in a social environment that is quite different from the one experienced by male debaters.

The pattern is noticeably different among coaches. While female coaches were more likely than male coaches to experience some forms of harassment, such differences usually occurred in the category of events described as gender harassment or seductive behavior, rather than in the areas of sexual bribery, sexual coercion, or sexual imposition. Specifically, women were significantly more likely than male coaches to claim to be treated differently due to their gender, to experience sexist remarks, to be exposed to a discussion of personal or sexual matters, and to be subjected to unwanted seductive behaviors.

However, female coaches were no more likely than male coaches to hear suggestive stories or offensive jokes, they were not more likely to be bribed with some reward, they were not more likely to experience negative consequences for non-cooperation, they were not more likely to be subjected to threats for non-cooperation, they were not more likely to

Table 2. Males versus Females: Comparisons within Role Groups

1. Suggestive stories, offensive jokes	Male debaters	Male coaches
	78.36% (210/268)	91.67% (88/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	69.81% (111/159)	95.12% (39/41)
	$t = -1.976^* (p = .048)$	$t = 0.712 (p = .476)$
2. Treated differently due to gender	Male debaters	Male coaches
	27.99% (75/268)	34.38% (33/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	71.07% (113/159)	82.93% (34/41)
	$t = 8.670^* (p = .000)$	$t = 5.206^* (p = .000)$
3. Sexist remarks	Male debaters	Male coaches
	24.25% (65/268)	39.58% (38/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	56.60% (90/159)	82.93% (34/41)
	$t = 6.720^* (p = .000)$	$t = 4.652^* (p = .000)$
4. Discussion of personal or sexual matters	Male debaters	Male coaches
	32.84% (88/268)	50.00% (48/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	44.65% (71/159)	73.17% (30/41)
	$t = 2.442^* (p = .015)$	$t = 2.508^* (p = .012)$
5. Unwanted seductive behavior	Male debaters	Male coaches
	26.12% (70/268)	26.04% (25/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	38.99% (62/159)	48.78% (20/41)
	$t = 2.783^* (p = .005)$	$t = 2.595^* (p = .009)$
6. Bribe with some reward	Male debaters	Male coaches
	1.87% (5/268)	9.38% (9/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	12.58% (20/159)	12.20% (5/41)
	$t = 4.558^* (p = .000)$	$t = 0.499 (p = .618)$
7. Unwanted sexual behavior due to rewards	Male debaters	Male coaches
	0.37% (1/268)	3.13% (3/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	1.26% (2/159)	0.00% (0/41)
	$t = 1.058 (p = .290)$	$t = -1.144 (p = .252)$

Table 2. Males versus Females: Comparisons within Role Groups (Cont.)

8. Negative conseq. for non-cooperation	Male debaters	Male coaches
	0.75% (2/268)	8.33% (8/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	7.55% (12/159)	4.88% (2/41)
	t = 3.815* (p = .000)	t = -0.712 (p = .476)
9. Threats for non- cooperation	Male debaters	Male coaches
	0.37% (1/268)	4.17% (4/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	2.52% (4/159)	12.20% (5/41)
	t = 1.990* (p = .047)	t = 1.737 (p = .082)
10. Forcible attempts to touch, kiss, grab	Male debaters	Male coaches
	3.73% (10/268)	10.42% (10/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	18.24% (29/159)	19.51% (8/41)
	t = 5.031* (p = .000)	t = 1.443 (p = .149)
11. Unwanted attempt to touch or fondle	Male debaters	Male coaches
	4.85% (13/268)	14.58% (14/96)
	Female debaters	Female coaches
	20.13% (32/159)	24.39% (10/41)
	t = 4.970* (p = .000)	t = 1.383 (.167)

* $p \leq .05$, two-tailed test

Note: Figures in parentheses are frequencies. For each cell, a t-statistic and a probability value based on the t-statistic and the sample size are provided. Calculations were done on data provided in Stepp and Gardner (2001).

experience forcible attempts to touch, kiss, or grab, and they were not more likely to be subjected to unwanted attempts to touch or fondle. In short, while gender differences in harassment are pervasive among debaters and persist throughout the 1990s, gender differences in harassment among coaches are more complex. Female coaches may experience a somewhat more hostile environment than male coaches, but they are not more likely to be subjected to the more intrusive and threatening aspects of sexual harassment.

Additionally, future research needs to examine the sources of differences in the experiences of debaters. Stepp (2001) relates several individually compelling anecdotes in order to paint a more clear picture of how females experience the debate environment, but such anecdotes can never take the place of more systematic research. Indeed, Stepp

suggests that future surveys examine the sex of the harasser, which would be helpful. Numerous studies indicate that female debaters feel that their arguments are evaluated differently than those of male debaters, that they are evaluated more negatively for assertiveness, and that there are different rules for how females in the activity are supposed to behave. (See Stepp, 2001, for a discussion of such findings; also, see Rudman and Glick, 2001, for social and workplace effects.) Existing surveys do not explain how these norms evolve or how they are enforced.

The prevailing assumption in the extant research seems to be that males are responsible for the creation and perpetuation of such norms. For example, Stepp (2001) notes: "Sexist remarks made by men about the presence of women in forensics, unwanted seductive behaviors, and unwanted attempts to touch and fondle may be reminders to women that they should be sexually attractive, noncompetitive and less powerful" (p. 45). This is one possible scenario, which, again, is yet to be substantiated by more directed research. A second possibility is that females are generating and maintaining the norms for women's behavior in debate. For those of us women who spent our undergraduate years as debaters in the 1980s, complaints about unfair treatment from female judges and coaches were as pervasive, if not more pervasive, than complaints about sexist male judges (see Biernat and Fuegen, 2001, for an example of female bias against women in the hiring process). Researchers should not simply assume that males are responsible for establishing standards of gender-appropriate attire, or what constitutes an acceptable level of assertiveness among female debaters. Existing surveys do not contain sufficient measures even to test such a hypothesis. Rather than attempting to use an all-purpose educational psychology measure (the SEQ) that is specifically designed to measure harassment in the workplace, those who research harassment in debate and forensics should draw upon their own experiences in the activity to tailor measurement instruments to the peculiarities of the environment they study. The use of anecdotes such as those related by Stepp (2001) can also provide valuable insights about what kinds of questions researchers ought to be asking. Absent the appropriate variables, even complex statistical tests will not provide useful results.

Harassment as an Expression of Dominance? Stepp (2001) suggests that women in debate may be more likely to be harassed as punishment for being assertive in a male-dominated environment where pre-existing social-cultural norms create an expectation of female passivity. In particular, she asserts that women are more likely to be novices in intercollegiate debate, creating an ability gap between male and female participants that

gives males participants in the activity greater power. This, Stepp predicts, should be a source of sexual harassment of females in debate and should lead to more harassment of women in debate than in individual events, where women participate in greater numbers and are more likely to be experienced in the activity.

Such claims are problematic on several levels. First, Stepp (2001) commits an ecological fallacy by arguing that women are more likely to be novices, then comparing men and women and assuming that any observed gender differences are due to inexperience and vulnerability. While Stepp finds some evidence that gender differences are more prevalent in debate than in individual events, her results are difficult to evaluate because she does not provide any gender breakdowns of reported harassment in these groups. Thus, it is impossible for a reader to calculate female debater versus female individual events differences and determine if, in fact, they are significant.

Even if we were to assume that in the real world Stepp's prediction of greater sexual harassment of women in debate is correct, this would not be sufficient to validate the underlying hypothesis of harassment as an expression of power and dominance. Finding that women are more likely to be novices and that women are more likely to be harassed does not, in fact, prove that any novices are being harassed. Indeed, we could find this same pattern if no female novices were being harassed, but all other women were. The only way Stepp's theory can ever be supported is if researchers studying harassment in debate were to also classify survey respondents by their number of years in the activity. Then, we could compare female novices with male novices to determine if women are more likely to be harassed, and we could also compare gender and harassment among novices. Given that most of the existing surveys on sexual harassment in various debate and speech associations have been conducted at national tournaments, where the presence of novices is less common than at other tournaments, it seems most inappropriate for Stepp to draw conclusions about female inexperience as a reason for sexual harassment. None of the subjects she examines is likely to be inexperienced, thus such generalizations are not appropriate under the circumstances.

Perhaps a more compelling reason to reject the claim of sexual harassment as a dominance issue in debate can be found in the data provided by Stepp and Gardner (2001). The Stepp and Gardner data were recalculated to provide frequencies for each group (males, females, debaters, coaches) for each year studied (1994, 1999). As noted earlier, there is little evidence to suggest that the pattern of responses to the SEQ differed from one year to

the next, so for each group the years were pooled. Then, for each SEQ item, experiences of male coaches were compared with experiences of male debaters, and female coaches were compared to female debaters. For each comparison, a two-tailed t-test for the differences between groups was performed using the formula provided in Equation 1. Statistically significant differences (based on an alpha of .05, or a confidence level of 95 percent) are designated by an asterisk. These findings are reported in Table 3.

Table 3. Comparisons of Coaches and Debaters within Gender Groups

	Male Debaters versus Male Coaches	Female Debaters versus Female Coaches
1. Suggestive stories, offensive jokes	Male debaters 78.36% (210/268) Male coaches 91.67% (88/96) $t = 2.094^* (p = .004)$	Female debaters 69.81% (111/159) Female coaches 95.12% (39/41) $t = 3.337^* (p = .001)$
2. Treated differently due to gender	Male debaters 27.99% (75/268) Male coaches 34.38% (33/96) $t = 1.176 (p = .240)$	Female debaters 71.07% (113/159) Female coaches 82.93% (34/41) $t = 1.534 (p = .125)$
3. Sexist remarks	Male debaters 24.25% (65/268) Male coaches 39.58% (38/96) $t = 2.861^* (p = .004)$	Female debaters 56.60% (90/159) Female coaches 82.93% (34/41) $t = 3.091^* (p = .002)$
4. Discussion of personal or sexual matters	Male debaters 32.84% (88/268) Male coaches 50.00% (48/96) $t = 2.983^* (p = .003)$	Female debaters 44.65% (71/159) Female coaches 73.17% (30/41) $t = 3.256^* (p = .001)$
5. Unwanted seductive behavior	Male debaters 26.12% (70/268) Male coaches 26.04% (25/96) $t = -0.015 (p = .988)$	Female debaters 38.99% (62/159) Female coaches 48.78% (20/41) $t = 1.136 (p = .256)$

Table 3. Comparisons of Coaches and Debaters within Gender Groups (Cont.)

6. Bribe with some reward	Male debaters	Female debaters
	1.87% (5/268)	12.58% (20/159)
	Male coaches	Female coaches
	9.38% (9/96)	12.20% (5/41)
	$t = 3.283^* (p = .001)$	$t = -0.066 (p = .947)$
7. Unwanted sexual behavior due to rewards	Male debaters	Female debaters
	0.37% (1/268)	1.26% (2/159)
	Male coaches	Female coaches
	3.13% (3/96)	0.00% (0/41)
	$t = 2.219^* (p = .026)$	$t = -0.722 (p = .470)$
8. Negative conseq. for non-cooperation	Male debaters	Female debaters
	0.75% (2/268)	7.55% (12/159)
	Male coaches	Female coaches
	8.33% (8/96)	4.88% (2/41)
	$t = 3.902^* (p = .000)$	$t = -0.597 (p = .550)$
9. Threats for non-cooperation	Male debaters	Female debaters
	0.37% (1/268)	2.52% (4/159)
	Male coaches	Female coaches
	4.17% (4/96)	12.20% (5/41)
	$t = 2.740^* (p = .006)$	$t = 2.666^* (p = .008)$
10. Forcible attempts to touch, kiss, grab	Male debaters	Female debaters
	3.73% (10/268)	18.24% (29/159)
	Male coaches	Female coaches
	10.42% (10/96)	19.51% (8/41)
	$t = 2.466^* (p = .014)$	$t = 0.187 (p = .851)$
11. Unwanted attempt to touch or fondle	Male debaters	Female debaters
	4.85% (13/268)	20.13% (32/159)
	Male coaches	Female coaches
	14.58% (14/96)	24.39% (10/41)
	$t = 3.122^* (p = .002)$	$t = 0.598 (p = .550)$

* $p \leq .05$, two-tailed test

Note: Figures in parentheses are frequencies. For each cell, a t-statistic and a probability value based on the t-statistic and the sample size are provided. Calculations were done on data provided in Stepp and Gardner (2001).

As Table 3 shows, for males coaches were more likely than debaters to hear suggestive stories or offensive jokes; to experience sexist remarks; to be exposed to a discussion of personal or sexual matters; to be bribed with some reward; to experience unwanted sexual behavior due to rewards; to be subjected to negative consequences for non-cooperation; to experience threats for non-cooperation; or to be subjected to forcible attempts to touch, kiss, or grab. Further, male coaches were more likely than male debaters to be victims of unwanted attempts to touch or fondle. Female coaches were more likely than female debaters to hear suggestive stories or offensive jokes, to be subjected to sexist remarks, to be exposed to discussions of personal or sexual matters, and to receive threats for non-cooperation. In no instances were debaters more likely to experience harassment than coaches.

Such a finding serves to undermine the assumptions of researchers such as Stepp that individuals with less experience, or in less powerful positions, are more likely to be subjected to harassment. Here, we find quite the opposite. Those presumably in the more powerful positions and possessing the greater expertise are more likely to be subjected to harassment than are those in weaker positions and possessing less expertise. And, males and females exhibit similar patterns.

Tantalizing as these findings are, however, they reveal nothing about the underlying dynamic responsible for such a pattern. We don't know, for example, who is harassing male coaches. It may be debaters, it may be other coaches, or it may be a combination of the two. We don't know if male coaches are being harassed primarily by women, by men, or by both. Similar questions apply to female coaches. (Researchers usually assume that females are being harassed by males, but at the moment, there is no data to back up this assumption.)

These findings emphasize the need for better studies on sexual harassment in the forensic and debate community. Given the unusual pattern of harassment shown in Table 3, we should also start thinking about other explanatory variables not utilized in current research that may prove helpful in disentangling the complex pattern of gender effects in sexual harassment.

Conclusion: On Policy Effectiveness

In light of this essay's focus on research design and measurement, along with statistical analysis and data interpretation, a final consideration of the policy recommendations advanced in the extant research on sexual harassment in intercollegiate debate is warranted.

Determining the effectiveness of the Cross Examination Debate Association's sexual harassment policy is troublesome for a variety of reasons. First, CEDA does not keep any comprehensive records of reported incidents of harassment, except for those instances that occur at the national tournament. Given that this tournament does not constitute the bulk of activity in the community, this information is not particularly helpful in determining how pervasive the problem of sexual harassment is, or whether it is on the rise or the decline. Thus, researchers have been forced to rely on convenience survey data, which may or may not be useful for drawing inferences about the extent of the problem.

Moreover, the survey being used to measure the incidence of sexual harassment in CEDA is, in itself, problematic. As previously stated, no attempt has been made to validate its use outside of its intended setting, and it is not clear that the items used are relevant to the study of harassment in a co-educational, extracurricular, non-workplace setting. Yet, Stepp (2001) concludes that, "unfortunately, this study indicates that the CEDA policy is having little impact" (p. 46).

The current essay suggests that Stepp's (2001) conclusion is premature. We simply don't know how widespread sexual harassment in the debate and forensic community is at this time, and the most recent research does not provide much insight where this question is concerned. On the basis of a few non-representative, self-selecting questionnaires administered under a variety of potentially biasing circumstances, it appears that the most serious varieties of sexual harassment complaints are not common. However, we have no idea who is harassing whom, under what circumstances, or how frequently. Given the small number of reports of forcible contact, we are left to wonder what, if anything, this tells us about the values and behaviors of the community at large. For example, it is entirely possible that all of the reports of forcible contact involve a single perpetrator with several victims. Alternatively, there may be many unmeasured incidents out there because researchers have not yet asked the right questions of the right respondents in the right setting.

Additionally, for those who are interested in studying policy effectiveness, several things need to be kept in mind. First, and foremost, the implementation of any policy generally has several intended consequences, only one of which is behavioral change. Other objectives may include learning and education about the problem, something the CEDA community does attempt to do with workshops on the sexual harassment issue at some of its meetings. Additionally, the creation of a standardized system of reporting complaints, a set

of uniform penalties, an appeals process, and the like are often objectives of policies. Yet, none of the studies on sexual harassment in CEDA attempts to investigate whether or not these policies and procedures have been successfully implemented, and a convenience study of public opinion may not be the appropriate way to make such a determination in any event.

Moreover, one could easily make the argument that if reports of sexual harassment were on the rise after the implementation of a policy designed to facilitate such reports, then the policy can be considered effective. Even if the overall number of instances of sexual harassment is down, a climate that facilitates reporting may show a surge in the number of individuals willing to be identified as victims. Given that the total number of incidents of sexual harassment is unknown, and that no systematic, valid estimate existed either prior to the existence of the policy or afterward, non-representative self-reports have little to do with whether the phenomenon is on the rise or the decline. Much like rape awareness programs, where increased reporting is a recognizable objective (as is education, both for potential victims and perpetrators), a sexual harassment policy that fosters a climate where individuals feel free to report their experiences may well provide more complaints from victims. If we were to see such an outcome after the implementation of a policy, it should not be considered undesirable.

In closing, while the tone of this essay has often been critical, we should not question the valuable service provided to the debate community by those who have conducted research on sexual harassment. One can admire the efforts of the researchers and concede the significance of the research project while concluding that more work remains to be done. All those interested in these questions, one hopes, will continue to pursue them.

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